Wealthy Lady

By Joyce Carol Oates

INTRODUCTION

The morning routine for you or me usually consists of a shower, a toothbrush and a bowl of cereal. But for a society matron, it consists of writing checks – POWDER BLUE CHECKS – to various charitable organizations. However, this particular matron should be more concerned with her sanity than with her charity.

*Let me show you what life is **really** like for this Wealthy Lady. . . and maybe, just maybe you won't wish for riches anymore. From I Stand Before You Naked by Joyce Carol Oates*

LADY: *(Graciously)* I am performing the

rituals

of the body I woke up in

sweet smiles writing

checks

I am the lady of the house

this house you've gazed at

from the outside Yes

some of you have wondered

what it looks like

on the outside

Well -- it ***is*** nice! *(Pause)*

Yes I am the lady of the house

this is my boudoir

I am doing what I do best

I am writing writing

POWDER BLUE CHECKS

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(Pause, as SHE writes, tears check out from book, etc.)

I am "prolific" I am much admired
I am happy to be so much admired
as I smile smile
writing writing
checks FLUTTER BLUE
on! In all directions!
(As if in a sudden breeze, checks flutter to floor.)

I am performing the rituals
oh! they're sac-red!
of the body I woke up in
I know ***my*** place
on this third-planet-from-the-sun
HEAPING RICHES LIKE GOD'S GRACE
into an emaciated face in a photograph --
Cambodian refugee no it's
is it? -- Ethiopian?
SAVE THE ORPHANS FUND
SAVE THE SYMPHONY FUND
SAVE THE REDWOODS FUND

I am smiling upon you all I'm in a good
  mood this morning
I slept well last night and I'll sleep well
  tonight
smiling upon the FRIENDS OF THE
  MENTALLY HANDICAPPED
smiling upon the FRIENDS OF THE

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ENDANGERED YAK

smiling upon the FRIENDS OF THE

ENDANGERED FETUS

I have many adventures with my checkbook

I SMILE UPON ALL RACES COLORS AND

CREEDS

(Sudden change of mood; yawns) An -- I'm a bit

bored my poor hand is ***exhausted***

(Rises from table, moves a bit stealthily)

Now I'll leaf through the portfolio

he keeps locked away

(LADY opens safe)

I'll finger these sacred papers

the quarterly dividend statements the money

manager's reports investments property

interest oh!

I suppose it's all in order, ***I*** wouldn't know

and --

(LADY has small pistol in palm of hand)

-- and ***here****!* --

which ***he*** keeps in the safe thinks ***I*** don't know

about

I WILL HIDE IT IN MY CLOTHES

(LADY paces about the room, fantasizing, excited)

I will cancel the FRIENDS OF THE ART

INSTITUTE luncheon

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I will attend today's Sotheby's auction
the Van Dusen estate poor Hendrik
there is a Goya up for bidding or is it a
Rembrandt!
Andrew Wyeth Van Gogh Jasper James
oh!
one or another!
I will bid gaily and drunkenly and when
I have bought everything when
the gallery officers approach me
then I will --

(Brandishes pistol)

No I will buy what remains of the Hinklemann
estate
and the old Quaker cemetery north of town
I WILL TURN IT INTO A LUSH LOVELY
MEADOW
I want sheep grazing rail fences inner-city
children
I want languorous mists that linger
cow-bells and vespers and shepherds with staves
Lombardy poplars for the balmy evening breeze
if the sheep get too filthy
if the children vandalize the monuments
IF ONE OF THEM APPROACHES ME --

(Brandishes pistol)

At the country club buffet I will toss food onto

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the floor

I will shake the champagne bottles FIZZLE

SPRAY ALL OVER

I will gaze upon my lifelong friends without

recognition

I will mutilate the ladies' fur coats

When I am approached when they say ***Won't***

you come with us

I will smile smile smile and

(Brandishes pistol)

No -- I will park the Mercedes by a warehouse

in my Gucci crocodile pumps I will go stumbling

through dark alleys

when I turn my ankle ***when I whimper***

when one of them **approaches**

oh! I will run I will be terrified I will pant like a

doe!

when one of ***them*** touches me

I will --

(Brandishes pistol)

YOU THOUGHT I WAS A DEFENSELESS

WHITE LADY DIDN'T YOU...!

(Abrupt change of mood, returns to table and pen, etc.)

Oh some other time

my migraine is

I'll cancel the luncheon though

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I almost forgot the FRIENDS OF GAELIC
they depend upon me
the FRIENDS OF THE GRAPE PICKERS the
FRIENDS OF THE BLIND
oh! already it's afternoon
the day will flutter by safely

POWDER BLUE SMILES ON ALL SIDES
but --
I am crossing off my list
the COMMITTEE FOR THE PRESERVATION
OF ST. TIMOTHY'S ABBEY
for it is chaired by a swine
who chews
celery
noisily

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
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